

ALONE FOR EIGHTEEN YEARS

Indian Woman, Abandoned on Desert Island, Finally Found by Party of Otter Hunters.

On San Nicholas island, which is uninhabited, a party of sea-otter hunters, landing to chance their luck, found, to their amazement, the imprint of human feet on the sandy shore—imprints freshly made. They scattered in search. But, the wind shifting and commencing to blow hard, they had to regain their vessel before the maker of the marks could be found. It was undeniable, however, a human being lived on this bleak, wind-blown island of sand and tall brushwood.

On returning to the mainland they reported the strange discovery, but nothing was done until a Roman Catholic priest was so moved by the news that he persuaded the captain of a small schooner to sail with him for San Nicolas. After two days' searching he discovered this lonely Crusoe—the first of a new kind. For he found inside a low hut of driftwood a woman more like a beast than a person.

She was clad in otter skins, and the feathered skins of the sea-fowl, and her companion was an otter, which she had caught very young and tamed.

The priest with difficulty got her story, for she had almost forgotten how to speak. Many years previously the small tribe of Indians to which she belonged—inhabitants of San Nicolas from time past—had been shifted by the government to the mainland. As they were being taken on board, her baby had fallen into the sea, and she had leaped after him, and in the dusk had been given up as drowned. She reached the shore, however, to find the child was dead. In utter loneliness she had lived there for 18 years.